

MNID 2026

A gathering of researchers advancing the science of neglected infectious diseases.

DATES

August 7–8, 2026

LOCATION

University of Wisconsin–Madison

VENUE

Microbial Sciences Building

WEB

mnidmeeting.org

Day 1 — Friday, August 7, 2026

Opening

11:00 – 11:30 am Registration and poster set-up

11:30 am – 12:50 pm Lunch buffet — MSB Atrium

12:50 – 1:00 pm Opening remarks and welcome

Keynote and Plenary Session 1

Moderator: Matt Anderson

1:00 – 1:45 pm Mycology Keynote — **Asiya Gusa**, Duke University
"Fungal stress adaptation by heat-mobile elements"

1:45 – 2:00 pm Q & A, discussion

2:00 – 2:25 pm **Usher Kanjee**, Washington University
"Screening for essential invasion ligand/host receptor interactions in neglected malarial"

2:25 – 2:40 pm **Damien Castor**, University of Iowa
"Discovery and characterization of mold-active antifungal compounds"

2:40 – 2:55 pm **Jiawen Fu**, University of Michigan
"Amino acid acquisition via Toxoplasma gondii transporter ApiAT6-3 determines parasite fitness across host environments"

2:55 – 3:10 pm Coffee break

Plenary Session 2

Moderator: Bin He

3:10 – 3:35 pm **Andrew Wagner**, Bowling Green State University
"The burning questions: understanding host–fungal interaction dynamics during thermal wound infection"

3:35 – 3:50 pm **Sophia Staggers**, University of Pittsburgh
"Elucidating the in situ spatial organization of intraflagellar transport (IFT) at the flagellar base in Trypanosoma brucei"

3:50 – 4:05 pm **Guolei Zhao**, University of Michigan
"A Candida auris–specific transcription factor drives clade-specific variation in adhesion, lipid metabolism, and host interaction"

4:05 – 4:20 pm **Sai Sashyanth**, Iowa State University
"Investigating how malaria parasites build an effector protein translocon from an ancestral nutrient pore"

4:20 – 4:35 pm Coffee break

Breakout Session 1

Moderator: Rob Striker

4:35 – 5:30 pm **Career Panel** — MSB 1520
Nic Wheeler (Assistant Professor, UW–Eau Claire) · **Dan Pensinger** (Scientist, Promega) · **Brianna Mullins** (COO, Salus Discovery) · **Terra Theim** (Program Coordinator, UW–Madison) · **Wendy Bedale** (Scientific Writer, Food Research Institute)

4:35 – 5:30 pm **Grand Challenges** — MSB Atrium

5:30 – 7:00 pm Dinner — MSB Atrium

Plenary Session 3 — Lightning Talks (3 min)

Moderator: Liza Loza

7:00 – 7:03 pm **Tahir Hussain**, Iowa State University
"PTEx components are important for Plasmodium transmission to the mosquito"

7:04 – 7:07 pm **Elena Rehborg**, University of Wisconsin–Madison
"Investigating the role of parasite G protein–coupled receptors in sensory processes and their potential as novel anthelmintic targets"

7:08 – 7:11 pm **Gabriella Matheny**, Ohio State University
"Histoplasma pathogenesis requires mannitol metabolism"

7:12 – 7:15 pm **Georgina Agyei**, University of Notre Dame
"An epigenetic regulator, Set202, contributes to host adaptation and survival in the pathogenic fungus Cryptococcus neoformans"

7:16 – 7:19 pm	Katie Metzner , University of Michigan <i>"Spatial CRISPR screen identifies Toxoplasma gondii secreted effectors modulating human E3 ubiquitin ligase RNF213"</i>
7:20 – 7:23 pm	Sammy Aboagye , Rush University Medical Center <i>"Unraveling the mechanisms of schistosoma death triggered by novel thioredoxin glutathione reductase inhibitors"</i>
7:24 – 7:27 pm	Emily Simonton , University of Wisconsin–Madison <i>"Paralogs of the Candida albicans TLO gene family form interconnected functional networks with incomplete redundancy"</i>
7:28 – 7:31 pm	Paola Ramos Irizarry , Duke University <i>"Elucidating thermo-adaptive mechanisms and cell cycle progression in Cryptococcus deneoformans"</i>
7:32 – 7:35 pm	Fengrong Wang , Iowa State University <i>"Cryo-EM structures reveal unique protein components in the 43S translation initiation complexes of apicomplexan parasite Toxoplasma gondii"</i>
7:36 – 7:39 pm	Nic Wheeler , University of Wisconsin–Eau Claire <i>"Ultrawidefield imaging for quantitative ethology of aquatic stages of parasites and vectors"</i>
7:40 – 7:43 pm	Brynn Elson , University of Michigan <i>"Scf1 suppresses the innate immune response to systemic Candida auris infection"</i>

Poster Session (with beverages)

7:45 – 8:45 pm	Poster session A (odd-numbered posters)
8:45 – 9:45 pm	Poster session B (even-numbered posters)
9:45 pm – end	Social outing @ Memorial Union Terrace

Day 2 — Saturday, August 8, 2026

Opening

7:30 – 8:30 am	Breakfast — MSB Atrium
8:30 – 8:40 am	Opening remarks and announcements

Keynote and Plenary Session 4

Moderator: Mostafa Zamanian

8:40 – 9:25 am	Parasitology Keynote — Lamba Omar Sangaré , Texas A&M University <i>"Mechanisms of placental barrier crossing by Toxoplasma gondii"</i>
9:25 – 9:40 am	Q & A, discussion
9:40 – 10:05 am	Rafael Polidoro , Indiana University School of Medicine <i>"A physiologically relevant mouse model of malaria-associated acute kidney injury utilizing transcutaneous GFR monitoring and expansion microscopy"</i>
10:05 – 10:20 am	Eli Cytrynbaum , University of Wisconsin–Madison <i>"Role and regulation of dispersal in Candida albicans commensalism and pathogenicity"</i>
10:20 – 10:35 am	Tarrick Qahash , University of Notre Dame <i>"Constructing a phenome: comprehensive QTL mapping in a Kelch13 wildtype Plasmodium falciparum genetic cross reveals alternative forms of artemisinin resistance and fitness is linked to transcriptional regulation"</i>
10:35 – 10:50 am	Coffee break

Plenary Session 5

Moderator: Josh Beck

10:50 – 11:15 am	Jose Thekkiniath , Purdue University Fort Wayne <i>"Understanding the role of parasite-derived vesicles in modulating immune responses to Babesia infection"</i>
11:15 – 11:30 am	Mark Hall , Purdue University <i>"Application of auxin-inducible protein degradation in mouse models of invasive candidiasis"</i>
11:30 – 11:45 am	Milad Ahmed , University of Cincinnati <i>"PDE-defined cAMP pools are functionally segregated in Trypanosoma cruzi"</i>
11:45 am – 12:00 pm	Zoë Reynolds , University of Illinois Urbana–Champaign <i>"Investigating Cryptosporidium parvum thrombospondin protein cpTSP2 in macrogamont development"</i>
12:00 – 12:15 pm	Closing remarks
12:15 pm	Lunch — MSB Atrium

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